

Chapter 2 – Fascinating Symbiotic Relationships

The first animals we encountered in the Amazon were capybaras. A family of five waddled leisurely out of the river, and on the head of one capybara stood a shiny black cowbird. The bird wasn't just taking a break—it was busy feasting on the fleas hidden in the capybara's fur. The scene was both comical and endearing, and it offered a perfect glimpse into the intricate web of symbiosis that thrives here.



On a sunlit stump by the river, several yellow spotted side-necked turtles were basking in the warmth. A few morph butterflies rested on their faces, drinking the salty tears that welled at the corners of their eyes. Our guide explained that many herbivores rely on such interactions to obtain essential minerals. Even bees sometimes come to sip their tears. Turtles aren't the only “providers”—caimans often become mineral sources for these insects as well.

Deeper in the forest, towering termite nests clung to tree trunks like oversized knots. They looked parasitic, but they were anything but. Termites do not harm the trees they inhabit; instead, they help protect them. When our guide tapped lightly on one trunk, an army of ants swarmed out within seconds, prepared to defend their home. The sight was unexpectedly impressive.



Termites are also valuable to local people—they can be crushed and applied externally to repel mosquitoes or taken orally to relieve coughs. Farther into the jungle, there is said to be another species: the *Myrmelachista Schumanni* ant. These ants fiercely patrol the base of their host *Duroia hirsuta*, clearing away the seedlings of competing plants and creating a protected, competition-free zone called “devil's garden” for their partner to grow.